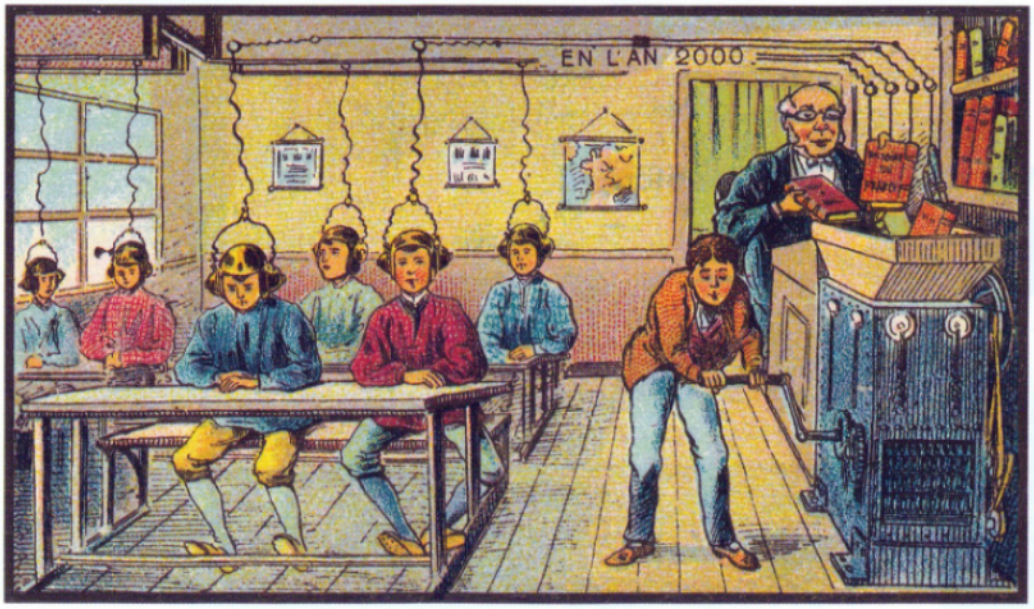
Futures Past

Prof. Will Glovinsky (wglovinsky@binghamton.edu) / Hannah Licht (hlicht@binghamton.edu)
ENG 180J / Fall 2026
Tues/Thurs 9:45-11:15 am
Classroom Wing 109
Office hours: Weds, 9-10 am (on Zoom); Thurs, 12-1 pm (LSG 680) (sign up here)



Jean-Marc Coté, "In the Year 2000" (1899)

Course Description

Writers, theorists, filmmakers, and planners have long speculated about the shape of things to come and asked how future developments might affect us. These predictions have sometimes been uncannily accurate: space travel, climate change, television, and even credit cards all appeared first in the pages of fiction. Other aspirations and fears have not (yet) been realized but continue to guide political, social, and ecological movements. In the fall semester of this stream, we will survey this fascinating history of expectation, dread, and yearning for possible futures, focusing on British and US cultural production since 1800. Our primary texts will include works of speculative fiction, literary utopias and dystopias, and science fiction novels and films; we will also consider political treatises and manifestos and modernist architecture and urban planning. A selection of influential critical and theoretical works will provide new vocabularies and methods to guide our discussions. As we investigate these strange and prescient visions, we will ask how speculation about previous eras of change can illuminate contemporary advances and challenges, from AI to genetic engineering to the climate crisis.

By the end of the fall semester, you will produce an exploratory essay and annotated bibliography that will lead toward an independent research project to be completed in the spring. The project will be focused on specific texts, social questions, technologies, or political movements of special interest to you. Joining close textual analysis with original research into the reception, adaptation, and afterlives of your chosen works, you will learn to use digital databases and other archival resources to tell compelling, critically informed stories about the futures of yesteryear—and what they mean for us today. This means that our course is as much about the *process* of research as it is about the *subject* of past visions of the future. We will be learning how to understand academic scholarship, formulate research questions, and locate primary sources. Throughout, we will be discussing how to write clearly and cogently about sources and organize a large-scale research project.

Course Texts

Hard copies of the following editions are required; all other readings can be found on Brightspace as PDFs

Thomas More, *Utopia* (1516) Penguin Classics, trans. Turner, ISBN: 9780140449105
Mary Shelley, *Frankenstein* (1818) Oxford World's Classics, ed. Groom, ISBN: 9780198840824
William Morris, *News from Nowhere* (1890) Penguin Classics, ed. Wilmer ISBN: 9780140433302
H. G. Wells, *The Time Machine* (1895), Signet Classics, ISBN: 978-0451528551
Aldous Huxley, *Brave New World* (1932) Harper Perennial, ISBN: 9780060850524
Philip K. Dick, *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) Del Ray, ISBN: 978-0345404473
Octavia E. Butler, *Bloodchild and Other Stories* (1984) Seven Stories Press, ISBN: 978-1583226988

Learning Objectives:

In this course students will:

- learn how past writers, artists, and activists have imagined the future, and how to explore these past futures in diverse ways: as critiques of existing social conditions, as elaborations of the consequences of novel ideologies and technologies, and as blueprints for possible alternatives
- become careful readers and analysts of literature, political writings, and film, paying special attention to how literary and rhetorical devices (irony, figurative language, mode of narration, motifs, etc.) shape the presentation of imagined futures
- become acquainted with a number of long-running political and social debates: how should power be distributed in a society? who should own property? how much equality is optimal? how should technological advances be regulated and implemented? what is the proper role of pleasure (sexual, gastronomic, social) in our lives? what is race and how might the concept evolve? what is 'the human' and how might technology alter it or blur its boundaries?

- learn to approach writing as a technology in itself—one that *slows down thought* and allows us to analyze ideas with greater precision, organization, breadth of sources, and conceptual rigor
- learn to approach the essay as a *problem-driven* genre. Essays are not only about making an argument; they are also about convincing a reader that there is something mysterious, puzzling, and unexplained about the topic in question. We will practice building essays around interpretive problems, developing thoughtful arguments that help illuminate those problems, and using evidence in sophisticated ways.

Gen Ed Learning Objectives:
Composition ("C")
Students will:

- research a topic, develop an argument, and organize supporting details;
- demonstrate coherent college-level communication (written) that informs, persuades, or otherwise engages with an audience; and
- demonstrate the ability to revise and improve written communication.

Humanities (H)

- demonstrate knowledge of the conventions and methods of a number of disciplines, including literary studies, history, and philosophy;
- recognize and analyze nuance and complexity of meaning through critical reflections on textual artifacts

Critical Thinking (T)

- clearly articulate an issue or problem;
  identify, analyze, and evaluate ideas, data, and arguments as they occur in their own or others' work;
- acknowledge limitations such as perspective and bias; and
- develop well-reasoned (logical) arguments to form judgments and/or draw conclusions.

Information Literacy (I)

- locate information effectively using tools appropriate to their need and discipline.
- evaluate information from a variety of sources with an awareness of authority, validity, bias, and origin.
- demonstrate an understanding of the ethical dimensions of information use, creation, and dissemination, whether from traditional sources or emerging technologies, such as artificial intelligence

Schedule of Readings

Note: The works listed for each day are to be completed before class that day so that you're ready to discuss them in class. Sometimes there are multiple readings per day. This schedule is subject to change with advance notice from Prof. Glovinsky.

Week 1
T Aug 18 – Introduction: Histories of the Future

INVENTING UTOPIA

Th Aug 20 – Thomas More, *Utopia* (1516), pp. 7-47 (Letters and Book 1)
– Complete Source Project Start of Semester Survey:
https://forms.gle/KbBsEfCH8ZeprWGY9

Week 2
T Aug 25 – Thomas More, *Utopia* (1516), pp. 48-113 (Book 2)
– George Orwell, "Can Socialists Be Happy?" (1943)

ORIGINS OF SCIENCE FICTION

Th Aug 27 – Mary Shelley, *Frankenstein* (1818), Vol. 1 (pp. 5-62)

Week 3
T Sept 1 – Mary Shelley, *Frankenstein* (1818), Vol. 2 (pp. 63-111)
– Darko Suvin, "On the Poetics of the Science Fiction Genre" (1972)
Th Sept 3 – Mary Shelley, *Frankenstein* (1818), Vol. 3 (pp. 113-172)
– Georges Méliès, *A Trip to the Moon* (1902)

Week 4
T Sept 8 – MONDAY CLASSES MEET

IDEAL SOCIETIES

Th Sept 10
– Chris Jennings, *Paradise Now: The Story of American Utopianism*, Ch 2, "New Harmony"
– Robert Owen, "A Sketch of Some of the Errors and Evils Arising from the Past and Present State of Society" (1817)
→ **Sunday, Sept 13 – Paper 1 Due**

Week 5
T Sept 15
– Charles Fourier, *The Utopian Vision of Charles Fourier*, ed. Beecher: selections from "The Ideal Community," "Attractive Work," "The New Amorous World"
– McKenzie Wark, "Charles Fourier's Queer Theory"

AFTER THE REVOLUTION

Th Sept 17 – Samuel Butler, “The Book of the Machines,” *Erewhon* (1872)

Week 6
T Sept 22 – William Morris, *News from Nowhere* (1890)
Th Sept 24 – William Morris, *News from Nowhere* (1890)

Week 7
T Sept 29 – H. G. Wells, *The Time Machine* (1895)
Th Oct 1 – H. G. Wells, *The Time Machine* (1895)
→ **Sunday, Oct 4 – Rewrite of Paper 1 Due**

BRAVE NEW WORLDS

Week 8
T Oct 6 – E. M. Forster, “The Machine Stops” (1909)
Th Oct 8 – Passage Identification Midterm Exam

Week 9
T Oct 13 – FALL BREAK
Th Oct 15 – FALL BREAK

Week 10
T Oct 20 – W. E. B. Du Bois, “The Comet” (1920)
Th Oct 22 – Fritz Lang, *Metropolis* (1927)
- Library Instructional Session with Matthew Harrick

Week 11
T Oct 27 – Groups 1 AND 2 read Le Corbusier, “The Street,” and Lewis Mumford, “Yesterday’s City of Tomorrow”
Group 1: SPECIAL COLLECTIONS VISIT
Group 2: Self-Guided Campus Tour

Th Oct 29
Group 1: Self-Guided Campus Tour
Group 2: SPECIAL COLLECTIONS VISIT
→ **Friday, Oct 30 at 5 pm – Paper 2 Due**

Week 12
T Nov 3 – Aldous Huxley, *Brave New World* (1932), chs. 1-6, pp. 3-106
Th Nov 5 – Aldous Huxley, *Brave New World* (1932), chs. 7-11, pp. 107-170

Week 13
T Nov 10 – Aldous Huxley, *Brave New World* (1932), chs. 12-18, pp. 171-259
Th Nov 12 – Ayn Rand, *Anthem* (1938)

THE POSTHUMAN

Week 14
T Nov 17 – Isaac Asimov, “Reason” (1941), “Runaround” (1942)
Th Nov 19 – Philip K. Dick, *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), chs. 1-8, pp. 3-89

Week 15
T Nov 24 – FRIDAY CLASSES MEET
Th Nov 26 – NO CLASS (Thanksgiving)

Week 16
T Dec 1 – Philip K. Dick, *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), chs. 9-22, pp. 90-224

Th Dec 3 – Octavia Butler, *Bloodchild and Other Stories* (1984), “Bloodchild” and “The Evening and the Morning and the Night,” pp. 3-68
Week 17
T Dec 8 – Octavia Butler, *Bloodchild and Other Stories* (1984), “The Book of Martha,” pp. 189-213
– Ursula Le Guin, “The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas” (1973, 4 pp)

Final Exam Date TBA
Friday Dec 11 – Exploratory Paper and Annotated Bibliography Due

Assessment

Participation and Preparation (10%)

This is a discussion-based class, which means that regular attendance is both essential and also the bare minimum (please see more on ‘Attendance’ below). Careful preparation and active participation are required to receive full credit for this portion of the grade. This means allotting sufficient time to complete readings, watch films, and take thoughtful notes ***with page numbers*** so that you are ready to share ideas, refer back to the text, and offer interpretations in class. Per Binghamton University’s website, you should be spending at least 9.5 hours per week on reading and assignments *outside of class*. Here are some other guidelines for good participation:

- take notes on class discussion
- ask questions and offer ideas to the class
- stay focused in group work
- have the day’s reading in printed (for required course books) or PDF (all other readings) form, in the required edition, on a laptop or tablet
- put away distractions such as phones (which should not be used during class or as your way of accessing readings)
- close unrelated computer windows and browser tabs
- take headphones (both of them!) out of your ears in a classroom

We may have a number of short reading quizzes which will count towards your Participation and Preparation grade. Quizzes will not be announced in advance and cannot be made up if you are absent. They are very short (several multiple choice questions) and should take no more than 2-3 minutes.

Pen Pals (15%)

We will all have "pen pals" with whom you will share a correspondence about the readings. Think of this as a reading journal, with a twist—you're writing and responding *to* a classmate. Each week, I will post a list of topics/questions on Brightspace related to the readings; from these topics you can select one or several to discuss with your pen pal, though you are also welcome to write about any other aspects of the reading that interest you. **You will be responsible for one letter a week. The first writer (whoever's last name comes first in the alphabet) will "send" their letter by Tuesday night (by 11:59 pm) and the second will "respond" by Thursday night**. At the mid-point of the semester we'll switch who writes first and who responds, to make things fair.

Letters should be about **a good-sized paragraph in length (about half a page)** and should all be written in a Google doc which I will share with you and your partner. Be a good pen pal! Be sure to use some form of salutations and sign off. Be thoughtful, curious, and kind in letters, and make sure to include specific references to or quotes from the text (with page numbers). Feel free to ask questions, share opinions, imagine scenarios, etc. Think of this correspondence as the 'sandbox' of our class: it's where you can work out ideas and test out theories. It doesn't need to be where you have fully thought-out readings. Letters will be graded independently.

Paper 1 (15%)

5 pages incl. MLA bibliography (10% on first draft, 5% on thorough rewrite based on professor feedback). Prompts for all papers will be posted in advance on Brightspace.

Paper 2 (15%)

6 pages incl. MLA bibliography

Exploratory Paper and Annotated Bibliography (25%)

9 pages. This paper should draw on primary and secondary sources and function as a stepping-stone to your spring project. MLA or Chicago Bibliography

Passage Identification Exams (20%)

Midterm (10%) and final exam (10%). The Passage ID exams are designed to assess how well you have been keeping up with reading and reviewing course material. You will be presented with 12 short passages from our readings. Of these, you must choose 10 and identify, in a few words, the work, author, context, and speaker (e.g., which character or narrator). Then, in two or three sentences, you will examine those features of the passage that reflect the thematic and/or stylistic elements of the work as a whole.

Attendance

You should attend all classes to maximize your participation and preparation grade (and to not miss any quizzes we have). You are permitted two absences during the entire semester. These absences should be reserved for sickness and personal emergencies. Further absences will begin to adversely affect your final grade; if you miss 6 classes you cannot pass the course.

If you miss class, you are responsible for reviewing one of your classmates' notes from that session and for completing and turning in any missed work promptly. It is not acceptable to arrive at the next class unprepared, with the excuse that you were absent. At the beginning of the term, consider forming an agreement with another student (maybe your Pen Pal!) to tell you what you missed if an absence is unavoidable. You can do the same for them.

Lateness is highly disruptive to class and three instances of tardiness (more than 5 minutes late) will amount to an additional absence.

Late Assignments

All assignments are due by 11:59 pm on the assigned day, unless otherwise specified, and must be turned in electronically as Google docs to the course website on Brightspace. Late assignments will receive a ⅓ letter grade deduction (e.g. from A- to B+) for every 24 hours they are late. In order to obtain an extension the student must obtain the course instructor's approval in writing (i.e. email correspondence) at least 24 hours prior to the assignment's due date. This means that emailing me an hour before the deadline will not result in an extension.

Electronic Devices in Class

You may use a laptop to access readings and take notes in class. However, note that use of a laptop involves its own etiquette: you should not text with friends, use social media, read the news, or do work for other courses while in class. If your eyes are excessively glued to the laptop I may ask you to close it. We will also have 'laptops down' moments where *all* laptops should close so that 100% of our attention is devoted to discussion, presentation, etc. You should always have a notebook and pen/pencil to take notes on during no-laptop time.

You may not use phones for accessing readings in class. Phones should not be out or used during class time.

AI Policy

This is a class about reading, thinking, and writing. Use of AI / large language models is not a substitute for thoughtful, graceful, or complex writing. Nor is it a replacement for the way writing slows down your own thinking, promotes learning, and organizes your arguments. AI isn't even

a highly reliable resource for research, as large language models work via prediction and frequently "hallucinate" (i.e. completely make up) fake facts, sources, and other evidence. For these reasons, use of AI (e.g. ChatGPT, Claude, Google AI, or any other similar service) to complete written assignments is prohibited and will result in consequences ranging from grade penalties on individual assignments to failure of the course.

Showing your work with Google Docs: All submitted written work must be completed in a Binghamton-based Google doc (accessible via the suite of Binghamton Gmail apps). You will submit your Google Doc assignment on Brightspace and make me (wglovinsky@binghamton.edu) and Hannah Licht (hlicht@binghamton.edu) an 'editor' of the doc. If I suspect that an essay is AI-generated I will check the Google doc's edit history. Your edit history must show the twists, turns, and gradual accumulation of your ideas as you formed them over many hours if not days; otherwise, it will receive, at best, a C. So long as the edit history is consistent with the process of writing and revision, your final grade will reflect only the final draft.

You similarly should not use AI as a replacement for reading course texts. Our passage identification exams are designed to be reasonably easy for any student who has diligently read a text and taken and reviewed notes. The exam passages will not be easily identifiable for someone who has only read a summary of the text (whether generated by AI or posted online).

I discourage the use of AI for brainstorming ideas—they will end up bland and predictable—but I have no way of checking this. So let me persuade you. There is already emerging evidence that using AI to perform intellectual tasks reduces brain activity and neural connectivity. I want you to learn in this course by deepening your creative and critical thinking skills. I'm sure you do as well. So I urge you to enjoy the time-honored methods of coming up with good ideas: (re)reading, silently arguing with authors, talking with friends and professors, free-writing/journaling, dramatically crumpling up pages and throwing them on the floor, etc.

What you *can* use AI for: If you choose to use AI to make sense of difficult concepts that is up to you. I would encourage you to begin with encyclopedias such as the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, Wikipedia, or Encyclopedia Britannica. If you do use AI to help you understand ideas, be sure to check its work with other tools.

Academic Honesty

Part of becoming a member of a scholarly community means giving credit to others for their ideas and work. You must distinguish clearly between your work and the work of others. To do otherwise may constitute plagiarism. You can avoid plagiarizing by doing the following: When you incorporate another person's words into your work, you must enclose them in quotation marks and provide a citation (footnote, endnote, or parenthetical citation). Even when you paraphrase another person's words or use another person's ideas or information, you must provide a citation. Only when the ideas, information, and words are yours alone is it permissible to include no citation. Be aware that weaving together another author's exact words with your

own, without appropriate attribution and quotation marks, is also considered a form of plagiarism.

Binghamton University defines plagiarism as:

Presenting the work of another person as one's own work (including papers, words, ideas, information, computer code, data, evidence-organizing principles, or style of presentation of someone else taken from the Internet, books, periodicals or other sources). Plagiarism includes:

- quoting, paraphrasing or summarizing without acknowledgement, even a few phrases;
- failing to acknowledge the source of either a major idea or ordering principle central to one's own paper;
- relying on another person's data, evidence or critical method without credit or permission;
- submitting another person's work as one's own; using unacknowledged research sources gathered by someone else.
- submitting work created in whole or in part by AI, unless with explicit permission of the instructor

You may also consult the following web resources on plagiarism:

Binghamton University Student Academic Honesty Code
https://www.binghamton.edu/watson/about/academic-honesty.html

Binghamton University Library's Guide to Citing Sources
https://libraryguides.binghamton.edu/citation

If you find yourself struggling with your writing assignments, please contact me and make an office appointment. You can also visit the BU Writing Center:
http://www2.binghamton.edu/writing/writing-center/

Plagiarism is a serious issue. If you plagiarize an assignment, you will receive a zero on that assignment and the incident will be reported to Harpur College.

Accommodations

I want us all to succeed in this class. If you have a documented disability you may arrange through Services for Students with Disabilities for accommodations. Additionally, if there's any way I can make your experience in this class more rewarding or engaging by accommodating a special need, please be in touch with me and we'll work together to hopefully find a suitable solution.

A Note on Our Identities

The project of learning together involves allowing all members of our community to grow and change the way we think, relate with others, and present ourselves to the world. We'll be respecting the way individuals ask to be addressed, but keep in mind that this may change: identities—and especially the ways they exist in and through language—are subject to revision.

Mental Health and Academic Stress Resource

If you are feeling extremely stressed and/or depressed due to your academic workload or personal issues, I encourage you to seek out the resources that Binghamton University provides on campus. You are always welcome to visit me during my office hours if you are having trouble with my course; for other issues that may be troubling you, you can consult the following:

* Dean of Students Office: 607-777-2804
* Decker Student Health Services Center: 607-777-2221
* University Police: On campus emergency, 911
* University Counseling Center: 607-777-2772
* Interpersonal Violence Prevention: 607-777-3062
* Harpur Advising: 607-777-6305
* Office of International Student & Scholar Services: 607-777-2510
* Ombudsman: 607-777-2388
* Services for Students with Disabilities: 607-777-2686

If something major comes up this semester that you know will impact your academic performance or cause you to miss classes, please contact me!

Mandated Reporting

Please note that, as your instructor, I am required by law to report incidents that may constitute sexual violence or sexual harassment to the university Title IX Office. If you or someone you know needs to speak with someone *confidentially* (i.e. who is not a mandated reporter) the following are confidential resources: *UCC Counselors, Decker Health Services, University Ombudsman, Interfaith Council and Harpur's Ferry.*